

Temperate grassland

Many continental regions are too dry for trees to form dense forests. Instead, the wild landscape is dominated by grassland. In the temperate regions, these grasslands are known as prairie, steppe, and pampas. The grasses can build up deep, fertile soils. As a result, much of this grassland has been used to grow crops, but some wild areas survive.

STEPPE AND PRAIRIE

Temperate grasslands develop in places where the climate is almost dry enough to create deserts. They often form in the heart of continents, beyond mountains that catch most of the rain. In North America, for example, the prairies lie beyond the Rocky Mountains. In Central Asia, the steppe forms a broad band across the center of the continent. Such places have continental climates with hot summers and cold winters.



▲ TREELESS STEPPE

Despite the clouds in the sky, little rain falls on the open steppe of Central Asia, and trees are very scarce.



THE TOUGHEST PLANT

Grass is a survivor. It can recover from freezing, drought, fire, and, in particular, intense grazing. It grows from near or below ground level, so if its leaves are chewed off, it just grows more. It is also studded with microscopic shards of glassy silica that wear away the grazers' teeth.



GRAZING HERDS

Grass is hard on teeth and hard to digest. But it is so abundant that many animals have evolved ways of eating and digesting it. They include antelope, wild horses, and these American bison, which live in herds for mutual defense from predators such as wolves. Bison once roamed the American prairies by the millions, before being hunted to near-extinction in the 19th century.

A big bull bison eats up to 33 lb (15 kg) of grass every day.

